Pakistani crises in light of the theoretical arguments that we offer in chapter 3. Ganguly argues that despite acute political differences and significant tensions, both sides understood the logic of nuclear deterrence. Even though they were prepared to engage in acrimonious exchanges and emplace troops and armor along disputed borders, neither side evinced much propensity for military escalation. Such restraint could only be attributed to the presence of nuclear weapons. Kapur maintains that ongoing regional conflict was consistent with the expectations of strategic pessimism. Nuclear weapons' ability to insulate Pakistan from all-out Indian retaliation and to attract international attention to Indo-Pakistani crises facilitated Pakistani attempts to undermine territorial boundaries in Kashmir. India responded forcefully, and the result was a cycle of regional conflict. Thus nuclear weapons encouraged risky behavior based on India's and Pakistan's rational calculations of their politico-military interests.

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In chapter 5 we discuss the South Asian security environment from 2002 to the present. This period has witnessed an improvement in Indo-Pakistani relations, as evidenced by the commencement of a peace process, the adoption of a raft of confidence-building measures, and a reduction in regional militarized disputes. Ganguly attributes these developments in large part to the pacifying effects of nuclear deterrence. Kapur maintains that security improvements have been modest and that nuclear weapons were not responsible for them. Instead, economic factors, domestic political pressures, and nonnuclear strategic considerations underlie the recent thaw in Indo-Pakistani relations. Kapur argues further that nuclear weapons actually triggered ongoing strategic developments that could destabilize the subcontinent well into the future.